



New era, new zeal: Mitchell Santner replaced Kane Williamson as New Zealand's white-ball captain late last year. AP

Can the pursuit of consistency finally lead to a title win?

Since 2011, the 2013 and 2017 Champions **Trophy editions** are the only 50-over ICC tournaments where New Zealand missed the semifinals.

Abhishek Saini

abhishek.s@thehindu.co.in

New Zealand's change of guard in One-Day Internationals (ODIs) had a lacklustre initiation with a 0-2 series loss to Sri Lanka in November, but the pieces are falling into place for the Kiwis as they head into the ICC Champions Trophy.

Since being named full-time

captain, Mitchell Santner has overseen a 2-1 series win over Sri Lanka at home in January, followed by comprehensive victories over host Pakistan and South Africa in the tri-nation series.

The wins in Pakistan will boost morale for a side that has lost 19 out of its 34 ODIs away from home since 2022.

The urgency with the willow has been the standout change under Santner. The team has scored at 6.38 runs per over in 2025, the fastest it has ever batted in ODIs.

Whether New Zealand can sustain this approach in the ICC Champions Trophy will depend on Glenn Phillips and Michael Bracewell in the lower-middle order. The